

# Democracy’s Data: Analytics and Insights into American Elections

[84-355] | Fall 2026

Prof. Jonathan Cervas

Updated: August 24, 2026

Professor Jonathan Cervas  
Office: Posner Hall 374  
Email: [cervas@cmu.edu](mailto:cervas@cmu.edu)  
Location: Porter Hall A21A  
Time: Tuesday & Thursday 11:00a-12:20p Eastern  
Office Hours: Wed 10:30a-12:30p & 1:30p-3:30p, and by appointment (ar-  
range via email)  
**CMU Academic Calendar**

The most up-to-date version of this **syllabus can be found here**.

**Course Relevance:** DC: *Perspectives on Justice and Injustice* **Learning Re-**  
**sources:** All resources will be provided via Canvas  
**Prerequisites:** 36-200 Reasoning with Data



**25 meetings**, Tuesdays and Thursdays. One of them, **Tue, Nov 24**, meets on Zoom rather than in the room. Tinted days are ones we do not meet — fall break, Democracy Day, Thanksgiving, and the Constitution Day Symposium.

How American elections actually work, taught through the data they produce. Tuesdays we read; Thursdays we put real election data on the screen and work out what it shows — through the 2026 midterms, live.

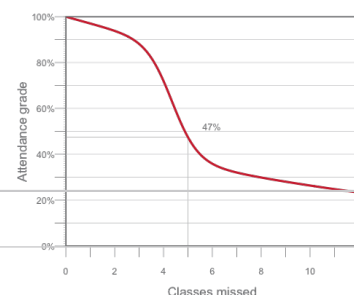
## 01 Assessment

The course grade will be a weighted average of the following components:

| Category                              | Percent of Final Grade |
|---------------------------------------|------------------------|
| <b>Participation &amp; Attendance</b> | 23%                    |
| <b>Discussion Board</b>               | 10%                    |
| <b>Surveys</b> (3, completion only)   | 2%                     |
| <b>Data Slides</b>                    | 10%                    |
| <b>Three Tests</b> (10% each)         | 30%                    |
| <b>Data Journalism Project</b>        | 25%                    |

## 02 Due Dates

| Assignment                                      | Due                                                                                                                      |
|-------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Data slide                                      | before <b>each Thursday</b>                                                                                              |
| Surveys (3)                                     | <b>Wed, Aug 26</b> (Cervas Election Study), <b>Fri, Oct 23</b> (midterm feedback), <b>final week</b> (course evaluation) |
| Discussion board post                           | <b>Friday, 11:59 p.m.</b> , each week                                                                                    |
| Data Session 4 board post (no Thursday session) | <b>Tue, Sep 22</b> — no session to follow that week, so you get the weekend                                              |
| Week 14 board post (Thanksgiving)               | <b>Mon, Nov 30</b> — Tuesday is on Zoom, and there is no Thursday                                                        |
| <b>Test 1</b> — Ch. 1-5                         | <b>Thu, Oct 8</b> , in class                                                                                             |
| Data journalism: pitch                          | <b>Tue, Oct 20</b> , in class                                                                                            |
| <b>Test 2</b> — Ch. 6-9                         | <b>Tue, Nov 10</b> , in class                                                                                            |
| Data journalism: <b>draft</b>                   | <b>Thu, Nov 19</b> — the term's last data session                                                                        |
| Data journalism: <b>peer reviews</b> (two)      | <b>Tue, Dec 1</b>                                                                                                        |
| <b>Test 3</b> — Ch. 10-13                       | <b>Thu, Dec 3</b> , in class                                                                                             |
| Data newsletter                                 | <b>Tue, Dec 8</b>                                                                                                        |
| Data journalism: <b>final</b>                   | <b>Fri, Dec 11</b> — after the last session                                                                              |



There is no final exam.

## 03 The Essentials

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- **Required text:** Sides, Shaw, Grossmann & Lipsitz, *Campaigns and Elections* (W. W. Norton). Everything else is posted on Canvas — there is nothing else to buy.
- **No coding, and nothing to install.** Every lab arrives as a prepared data brief with the results already in front of you; what you do is work out what they show.
- **Tests are on the textbook only** — in class, on paper.
- **Due Wed, Aug 26, 11:59 p.m.:** the Cervas Election Study — link in **Canvas, under Assignments**; screenshot the confirmation screen for credit. It is the first thing due, and your answers become one of the datasets we work with later in the term.

## 04 The Full Syllabus

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The session-by-session schedule, every reading and lab, assignment details, and all policies:

<https://jcervas.github.io/teaching/2026-2027/class-cmu-2026-84-355/readme.html>